

Penn
UNIVERSITY *of* PENNSYLVANIA



UPENN VS UIUC

Following the UPENN vs UIUC controversy where UPenn's band chanted "you (UIUC students) are going to work for me some day" during March Madness, the moment has sparked an online debate over which school's graduates are more "successful" post-grad. Using publicly available data, the analysis examines post-grad outcomes alongside public impressions of both universities.

Which alumni actually wins long-term?

mr_obasi82 1w

Illinois is literally ranked 9th best public university in America and has one of the highest starting pay statistics for alumni.

1,443 likes Reply

emmacynthiacastillo 1w

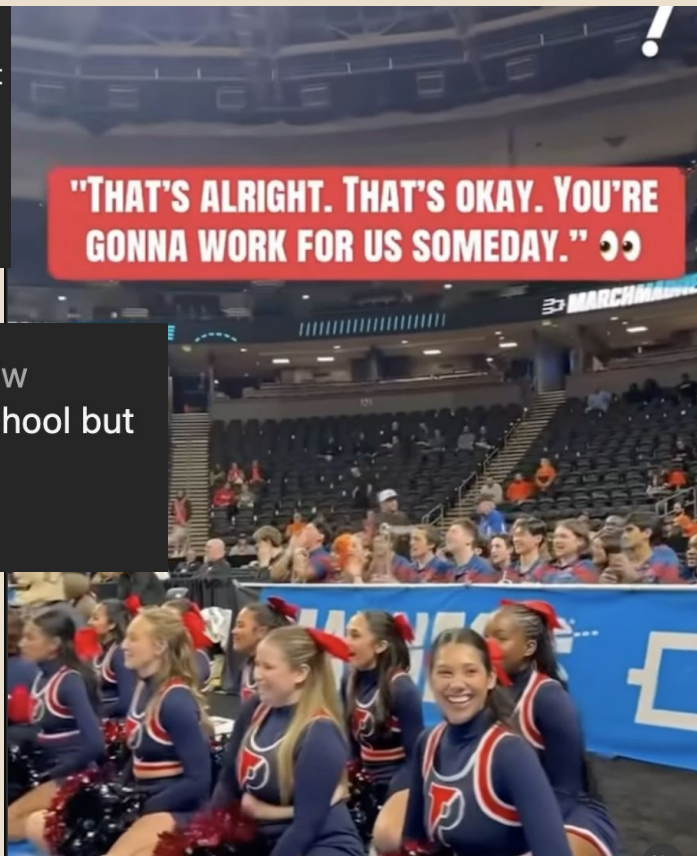
yeah maybe another school but uiuc..?

126 likes Reply

aravindimmaneni 1w

As an Alum of both Illinois (ChemE PhD) and Penn (Wharton MBA) I find this in very poor taste. I would hire an Illini before a Penn grad any day.

279 likes Reply



christinalorey • Follow
Original audio



christinalorey 1w
After losing by FORTY POINTS the UPenn student section would be funny to chant, "That's okay. You're gonna work for us someday."

How loser-y... but what'd you mean from Trump's alma mater?

They might want to do a little research and read up on Illinois alumni 💙💛



marie_suzanne_ 1w
This all started with Billy Penn when Penn (15) lost to Texas Tech and said this: "Don't forget to tell the Penn players. In 10 years they'll be working for us."



48



12



March 21

eric.schaaf 1w

I know a Billionaire who graduated from Illinois so there is that.

129 likes Reply

frankjgreen 1w

Illinois has the #2 accounting program in the country and top 10 engineering program....

39 likes Reply

david.heath.writer 1w

Maybe these students should have Googled University of Illinois first

51 likes Reply

Project Overview

Our project seeks to determine whether the University of Pennsylvania (overall, Wharton, and Penn SEAS) or the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (overall, Gies, and Grainger) produces stronger alumni outcomes across both business and engineering fields.

Our central research question asks: *Which institution delivers a stronger return on investment (ROI) based on post-graduation salary, career progression, and total cost of education?*

Hypothesis: Penn will outperform in absolute earnings and elite placements (especially in business). UIUC will be more cost-efficient and may achieve higher ROI, especially in engineering. Outcomes will vary by industry.



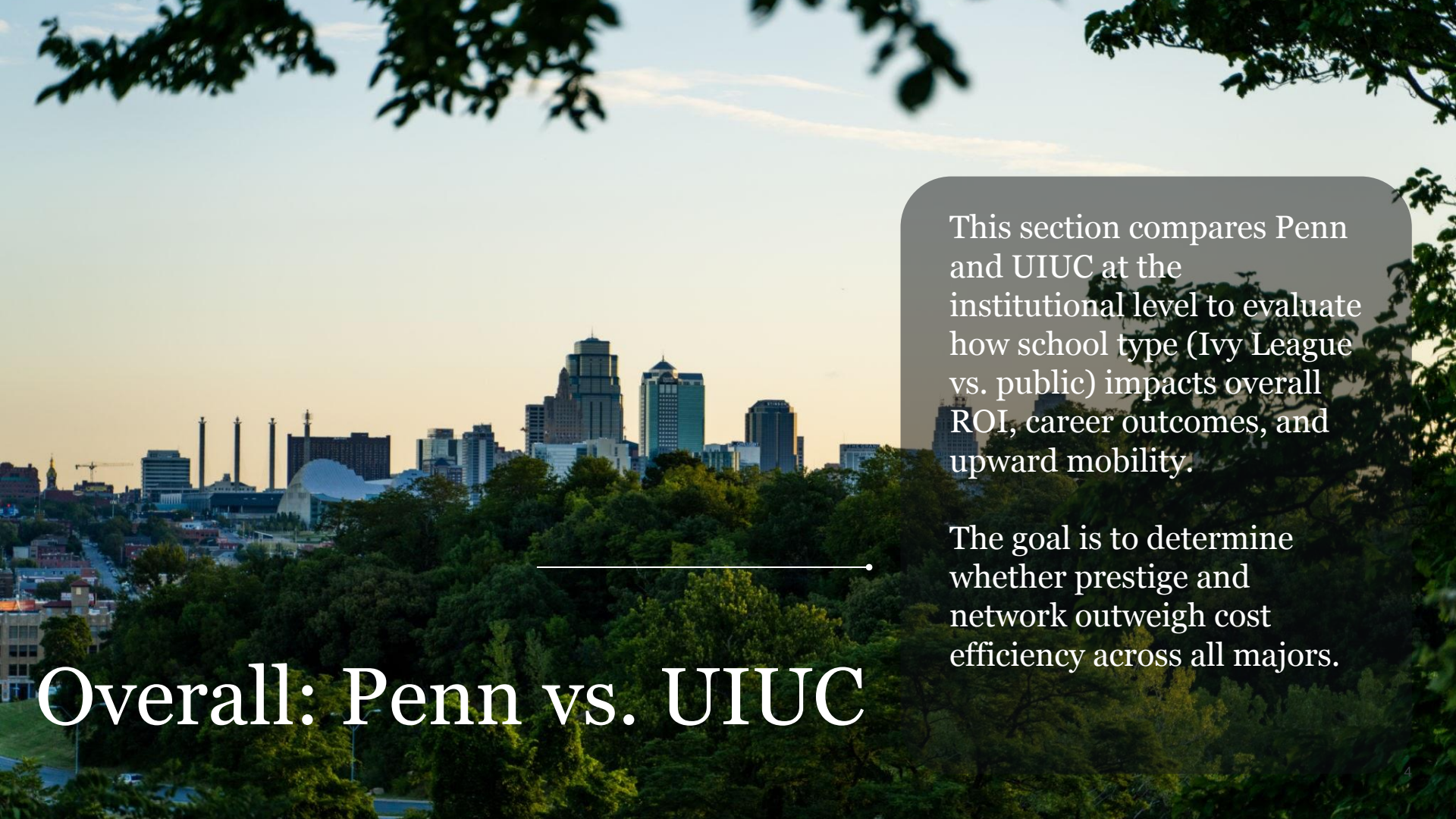
Quantitative

- Measure success using: median salary, industry salary averages, and employment rates.
- Compare financial outcomes: tuition vs. earnings (ROI) and average student debt.
- Track career placement: Fortune 500 / FAANG companies.
- Analyze mobility index.



Qualitative

- Conduct sentiment analysis using Reddit, LinkedIn, news, and student surveys.
- Evaluate alumni satisfaction, happiness, and career preparedness.
- Assess brand perception via media coverage and Google search trends.
- Review strength of alumni networks and career support systems.

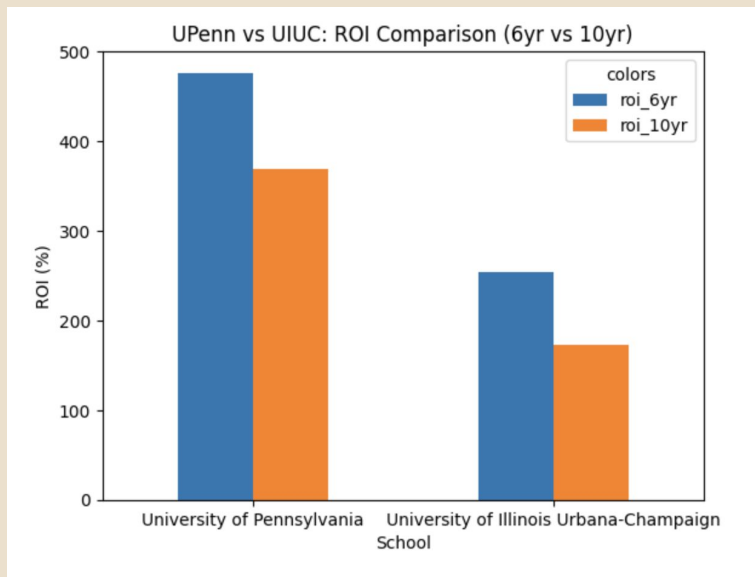


Overall: Penn vs. UIUC

This section compares Penn and UIUC at the institutional level to evaluate how school type (Ivy League vs. public) impacts overall ROI, career outcomes, and upward mobility.

The goal is to determine whether prestige and network outweigh cost efficiency across all majors.

Overall: ROI Comparisions

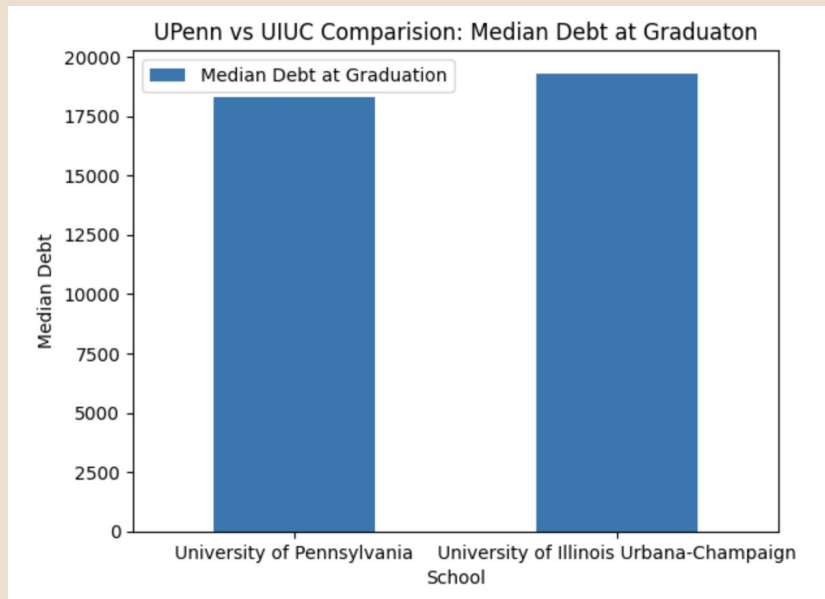


	roi_6yr	roi_10yr
School		
University of Pennsylvania	476.502732	369.398907
University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	253.475936	172.727273

Finding #1: Both schools follow the same shape with 6 yr ROI being higher than 10 yr ROI, which is striking because you would expect the income to grow, but this could be because of total costs (tuitions, loans, opportunity cost) compounding more than earning gains do in early career years, compressing ratio.

Finding #2: There is a significant gap between schools. Upenn's 6yr ROI is nearly double UIUC' as well as for during 10 year mark. UPenn has dramatically higher median earnings for graduates than UIUC.

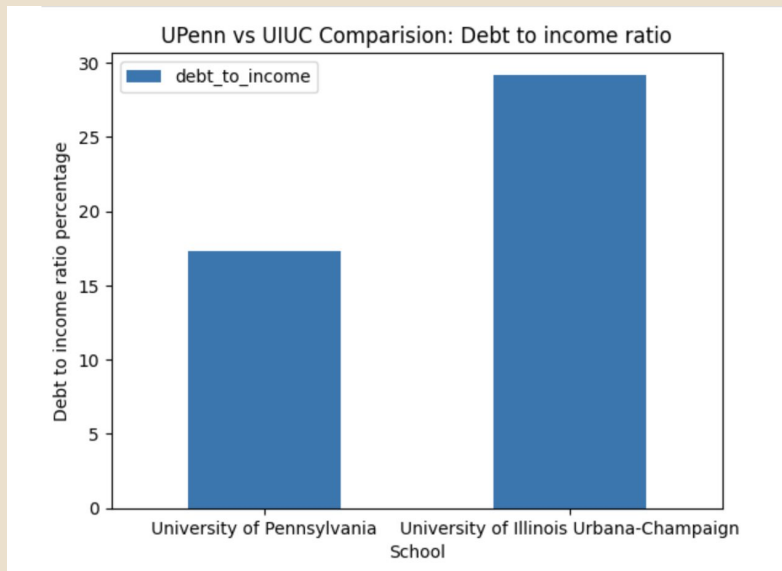
Overall: Median Debt at Grad



Median Debt at Graduation	
School	
University of Pennsylvania	18300.0
University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	19300.0

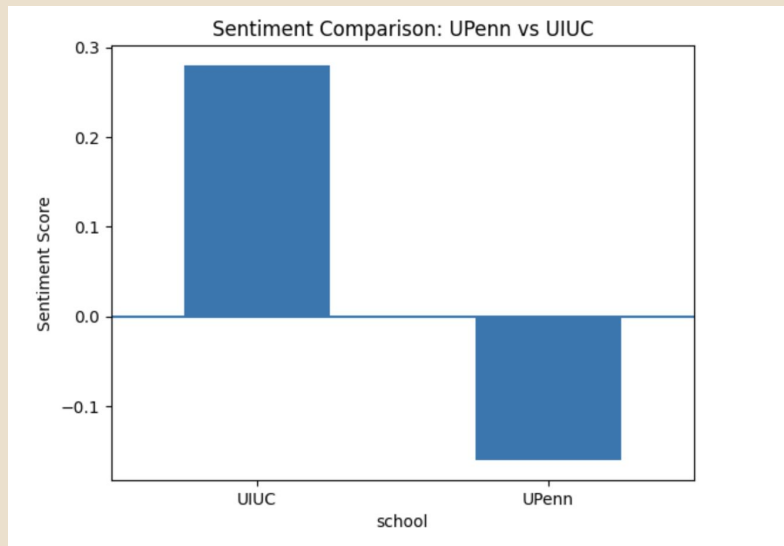
Finding #3: Overall debt levels are relatively close. The median debt for Upenn is \$18,300 and for UIUC \$19,300. Only a difference of 5.5%. UIUC has slightly higher median debt, which could be explained because Upenn has higher overall tuition as well as endowment resources, which can create stronger financial aid. Overall, both figures are both well below the national average of \$28,000-\$30,000.

Overall: Debt to income ratio



debt_to_income	
School	
University of Pennsylvania	17.345972
University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	29.198185

Finding #4: Following the median debt slide, while median debt figures were only 5% apart, here UIUC's ratio of 29.2% is almost 68% higher than Upenn's 17.3%. UPenn graduates holder a stronger financial position post grad with a 17.3% debt-to-income ratio. UIUC's 29.2% is extremely higher than the recommended threshold of keeping student debt below 10-15% of the annual income. This can indicate that UIUC students carry more debt relative to what they earn, earning less post-grad. Overall, UIUC students carry more debt.



```
school
UIUC    0.28
UPenn   -0.16
```

Finding #5: UIUC has a more positive sentiment score of +0.28 while UPenn is at a negative score of -0.16. UIUC alumni/students express more positive sentiment with UPenn alumni/students expressing more negative sentiment.

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Penn vs UIUC General Impressions

UIUC	Alumni survey / report	2.000000	UIUC	alumni sentiment / life satisfaction post-graduation	2.0	UPenn	alumni sentiment / life satisfaction	2.0
	News media	0.500000		alumni sentiment / school spirit post-graduation	2.0		alumni sentiment / life satisfaction post-graduation	2.0
	Niche / after-college poll	2.000000		campus life / student experience	1.0		campus life / safety / school spirit	1.0
	Niche / campus life polls	2.000000		clubs / research / social life	0.0		community / identity / campus feel	2.0
	Niche / critical review	-1.000000		competition / stress / life satisfaction	-1.0		competition / stress / belonging	-2.0
	Niche / graduate reviews	1.000000		general sentiment / happiness	2.0		depression / stress / campus culture	-2.0
	Niche / overall review	2.000000		happiness / social life / school culture	0.0		happiness / competition / fit	-1.0
	Niche / reviews summary	1.000000		inclusion / support for Black students	-1.0		happiness / life satisfaction / school spirit	1.0
	Reddit	0.000000		life satisfaction / belonging / school spirit	1.0		happiness / stress / life satisfaction	0.0
	Student newspaper opinion	-1.000000		mental health / depression / life satisfaction	-1.0		happiness / stress / social performance	-2.0
UPenn	Student newspaper reporting	-0.285714	UPenn	mental health / stress / wellness access	-1.0		life satisfaction / belonging / stress	-1.0
	Survey / institutional report	0.000000		news association / campus politics / grad-worker sentiment	-1.0		mental health / sadness / depression	-1.0
	Alumni survey / report	2.000000		news association / policy tension	-1.0		news association / campus climate	-1.0
	News media	0.000000		overall feel / belonging	2.0		overall sentiment / pain points	0.0
	Niche / after-college poll	2.000000		post-grad / graduate-program sentiment	1.0		post-grad / graduate-program sentiment	1.0
	Niche / campus life polls	0.500000		post-grad outcomes / alumni sentiment proxy	2.0		post-grad outcomes / alumni sentiment proxy	2.0
	Niche / graduate reviews	1.000000		sadness / depression / environment	-2.0		school association / campus culture	-2.0
	Niche / reviews summary	0.000000		safety / harassment climate	-2.0		school belonging / diversity	-1.0
	Niche / student review	2.000000		school association / belonging / retention	1.0		school belonging / social life	-2.0
	Reddit	-1.400000		school belonging / social connection	0.0		school spirit / athletics	0.0
UPenn	Student newspaper opinion	-1.000000	UPenn	school pride / competition / life satisfaction	1.0		school spirit / athletics engagement	0.0
	Student newspaper reporting	-0.400000		school spirit / athletics	2.0		school spirit / identity	0.0
	Survey / institutional report	0.000000		school spirit / community	2.0		student feedback / wellness concerns	-1.0
				school spirit / identity / controversy	0.0		student happiness / stress	-2.0
				stress / competition / happiness in CS program	-2.0		wellness infrastructure	1.0

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Penn vs UIUC General Impressions

UPENN: Upenn students struggle during school mostly

- Competition/stress (-2.0)
- School belonging/diversity (-1.0)
- Student happiness (-2.0)
- Life satisfaction (-2.0)
- School pride/campus culture (-2.0)

But have a more overall positive sentiment post grad..

- post-grad outcomes/alumni sentiment proxy (2.0)
- alumni sentiment/life satisfaction post-graduation (2.0)
- graduation program sentiment (2.0)

-

UIUC: UIUC students feel more positively about campus experience and community, but have concerning issues

- Alumni sentiment post-grad (2.0)
- Belonging (2.0)
- Post-grad outcomes and alumni sentiment proxy (2.0)
- School spirit/community (2.0)

Struggles with...

- Depression/Harrassment (-2.0)
- Competition/Stress (-1.0)
- Mental health (-1.0)
- Grad sentiment (-1.0)

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Penn vs UIUC General Impressions

Overall: UPenn outperforms on financial outcomes (better debt-to-income ratio), yet its community expresses more negative sentiment. Meanwhile, UIUC has a heavier debt burden but a more positive community outlook.

-Interesting to consider is how UPenn has a more negative sentiment during school, but a more positive sentiment post-grad.

-Upenn students still report significantly higher stress, lower belonging, and lower school spirit during their time enrolled, yet their ROI is substantially higher post-graduation. UIUC students report higher happiness and school spirit while in school, but lower long-term financial return. Is there a tradeoff between wellbeing during school and financial outcomes after graduation, or is it just because UPenn is an Ivy and UIUC a public in-state.

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Penn vs UIUC General Impressions

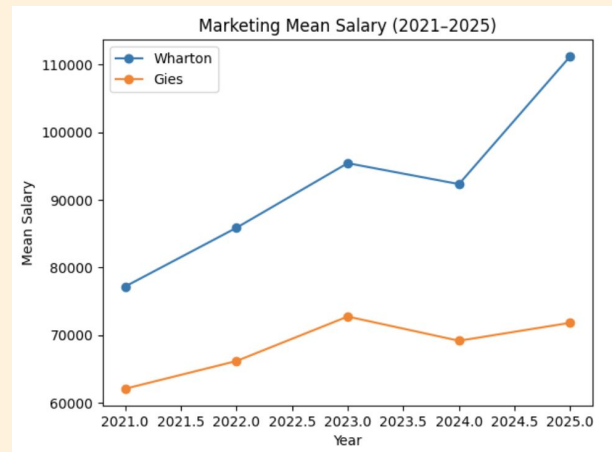
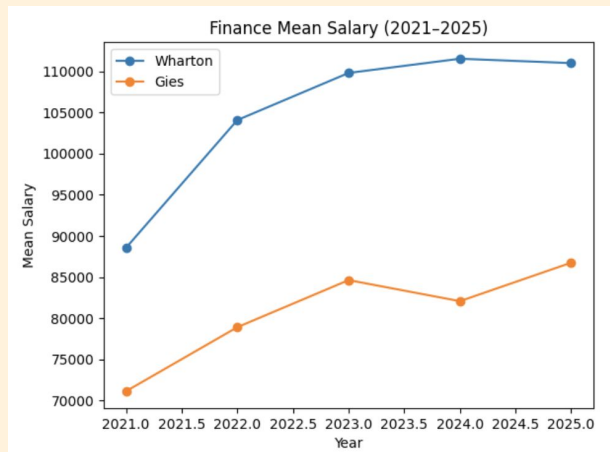
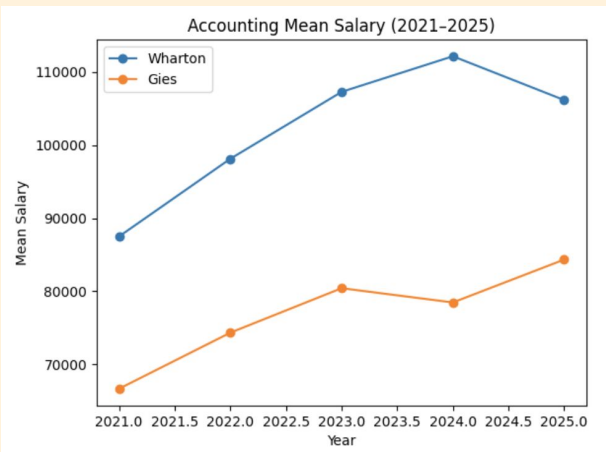
Business: Wharton vs. Gies

This section focuses on Wharton and Gies, selected for their distinct strengths: Wharton's elite finance placement and Gies' top-ranked accounting program.

We assess whether higher salaries and prestige or lower cost and specialization lead to better ROI and career outcomes. Next steps are to conduct qualitative sentiments.

Starting Salary Comparisons

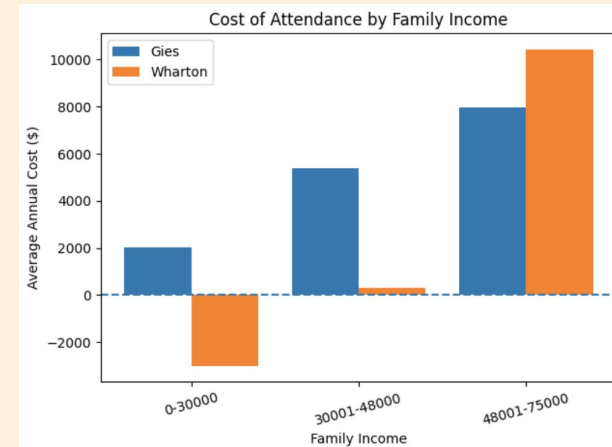
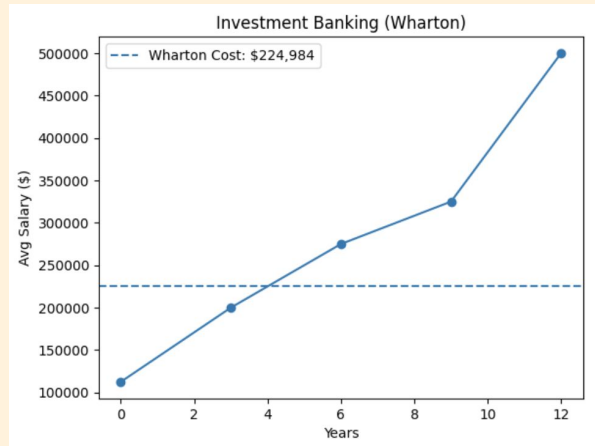
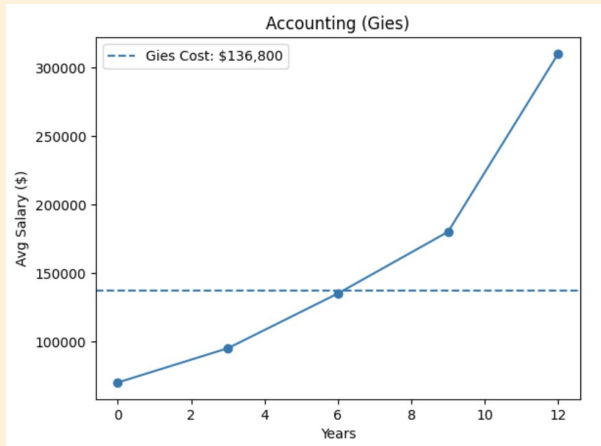
The initial step of my analysis was to compare average post-graduation salaries across business majors at both schools using data from their respective career services reports (2021–2025). Focusing on **accounting, finance, and marketing** (three majors strongly represented at both programs) I manually compiled salary data into a dataset to track trends over time. Gies is particularly known for accounting, while Wharton is highly regarded for finance.



The findings show that Wharton consistently reports higher starting salaries across all majors, but the trends reveal more nuance. In accounting, Gies salaries are rising while Wharton's appear to be declining slightly, suggesting Gies' strong reputation in the field may be closing the gap. In finance, Wharton salaries have plateaued around ~\$110K, while Gies is gradually. In marketing, both schools show upward trends, reflecting broader industry demand. Note: all Wharton students graduate with an economics degree and often enter high-paying fields like consulting or investment banking regardless of concentration, inflating salary averages, whereas Gies students' majors more directly align with their career paths.

The Return on Investment of Both Schools

The next step of my analysis focused on comparing ROI. Using average tuition data adjusted for financial aid and residency, I estimated a four-year cost of ~\$136.8K for Gies and ~\$225K for Wharton. Since school-specific long-term salary data is not publicly available, I used industry proxies based on typical career paths: Big 4 accounting for Gies and investment banking for Wharton. I then applied standardized 10-year salary progression data to model when graduates would “break even” on their education costs, while acknowledging limitations such as career switching and variation across individual outcomes.



The findings suggest that Wharton graduates (particularly those entering investment banking) achieve ROI faster (around ~4 years post-grad) and reach higher long-term earnings compared to Gies accounting graduates. However, results vary significantly by income level and financial aid. Data from College Scorecards shows that lower-income students at Penn often receive substantial aid, sometimes reducing net cost below Gies, while higher-income students pay significantly more. As a result, Wharton offers the strongest ROI for highly aided students pursuing high-paying fields like IB, whereas Gies remains a more cost-efficient and predictable option, especially for students following traditional accounting career paths.

Engineering: SEAS vs. Grainger

```
void showNote(int mm){
    FILE *fp;
    int i = 0, isFound = 0;
    system("cls");
    fp = fopen("note.dat","rb");
    if(fp == NULL){
        printf("Error in opening the file");
    }
    while(fread(&R,sizeof(R),1,fp) == 1){
        if(R.mm == mm){
            gotoxy(10,5+i);
            printf("Note %d Day = %d: %s", i+1, R.dd, R.note);
            isFound = 1;
            i++;
        }
    }
    if(isFound == 0){
        gotoxy(10,5);
        printf("This Month contains no note");
    }
    gotoxy(10,7+i);
    printf("Press any key to back.....");
    getch();
}
```

This section compares Penn SEAS and Grainger to evaluate outcomes in engineering, especially given UIUC's top-ranked computer science program and Penn's strong Ivy-affiliated engineering reputation.

The goal is to analyze whether technical strength or institutional prestige drives stronger alumni success.

Penn SEAS vs. UIUC Grainger

STARTING SALARY

PENN SEAS '24

\$122,500

median starting salary

avg \$138,360

UIUC GRAINGER '23-'24

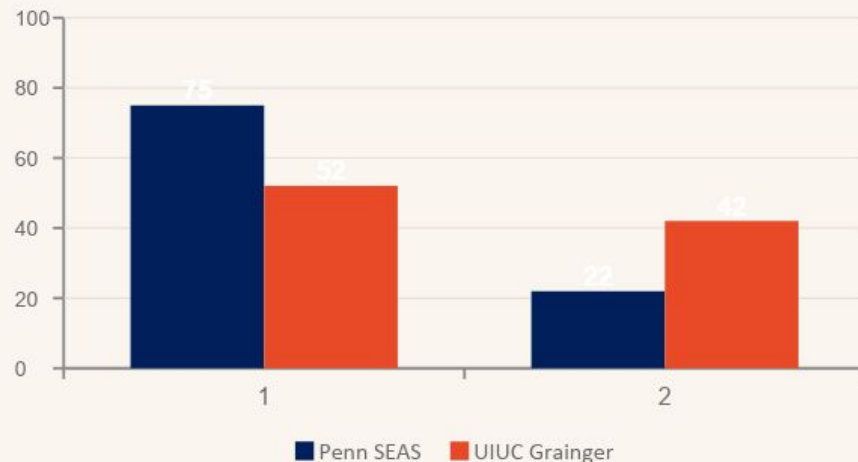
\$85,000

median starting salary

avg \$96,766

+\$37,500 median gap · break-even in **0.8 yrs**

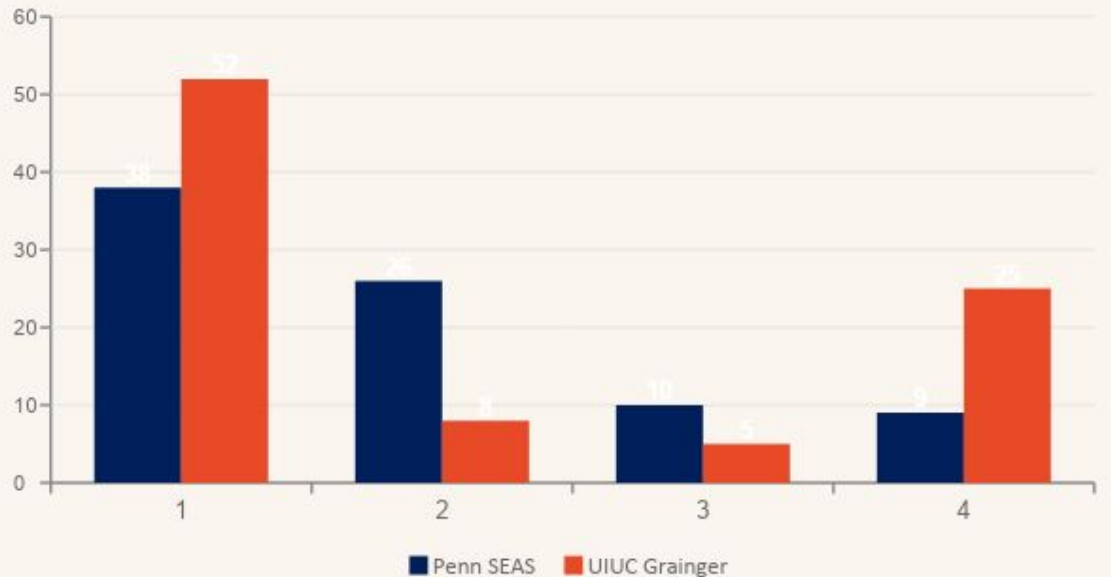
POST-GRADUATION OUTCOMES



Penn SEAS sends ~75% directly into full-time work. **UIUC Grainger** routes 42% into grad school — delaying labor-market entry and compressing near-term ROI.

Career Pathways & Key Takeaway

INDUSTRY PATHWAY (2023–24)



EARNINGS

Penn SEAS wins on salary

Median gap of \$37,500 is earned back in under a year relative to UIUC's in-state net cost.

REPUTATION

UIUC leads in pure engineering

#5 nationally (US News) vs. Penn's #19. But 42% of Grainger grads pursue grad school, delaying returns.

PATHWAY

Different outcome profiles

Penn SEAS feeds finance, consulting & tech. UIUC is a traditional engineering pipeline. Same degree — different destination.